

THE DHAKA DILEMMA

INEFFECTUAL: Chief Adviser of Bangladesh F. Ahmed



Despite repeated requests, Bangladesh's present regime is doing nothing to curb terror emanating from its soil even as India tries to bring the guilty of Hyderabad blasts to book

■ **By Saurabh Shukla**

Days before the Hyderabad blasts, a Central intelligence agency was monitoring the telephone conversations, made from a Hyderabad PCO, of a man with somebody in Bangladesh. He used to speak a mix of Bangla and Urdu and would tell his "friend" that he was on an important mission. He asked him to inform his mother that he would reach back soon, once the mission was complete. There were a series of calls which ended just days before the bombings in Hyderabad on August 25 that killed 44 people. The man, the agency now reveals, was Mohammed Shariffudin alias Abu Hamza, the prime suspect in the Hyderabad bombings, now believed to be back in Dhaka.

For India, there is a clear sign of trouble brewing again on the Eastern flank after the denial by Dhaka about the detention of Hamza. According to intelligence sources, he was trained in Balochistan in

Pakistan by its intelligence agency ISI and was running a module of Harkatul-Jehadi-Islami (HJI) from Dhaka that recruits, trains and carries out terror attacks in India. He had allegedly planned and executed the attacks on Mecca Masjid in Hyderabad earlier this year, along with the attack on the Special Task Force of the Hyderabad Police in 2005. Hamza, if caught, could help unravel information on the nexus of Jehadi organisations working in South Asia and their links with Al Qaeda. However, according to intelligence sources, while Bangladesh is unlikely to extradite Hamza, there is a likelihood that Americans may be inter-

ested in him because of his Al-Qaeda connection and they might take him away to Guantanamo Bay for further interrogation. Sources in Delhi say his detention was confirmed to the Indian intelligence agencies by sources within the Bangladesh Directorate General of Forces Intelligence (DGFI) on September 1. "We are seeking their cooperation," says External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee. Even though in an official statement Dhaka denied that Hamza was in its custody, officials in Delhi are not convinced.

In fact, when Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajashekhara Reddy pointed to a Bangladesh and Pakistan

connection in the blasts, he was referring to the inputs given earlier by the intelligence agencies. The issue is bound to add to a feeling of mistrust between the two neighbours. This is not the first time that Delhi has raised the issue with Dhaka in the past few months. While Prime Minister Manmohan Singh did some plain talk with the head of the

